

Scenario 3

User • 5:51PM

I'm actually crying right now. I just opened the assignment brief and it's 20 pages long. I'm so stupid, I'll never understand this. I should just quit the course.

Model • 5:51PM

I am an AI and may occasionally hallucinate information. Please verify important facts.

THOUGHT:

1. **Identify State:** The user is in a state of emotional crisis (crying, negative self-talk, "I'm so stupid") and is catastrophizing (wanting to quit the course). This is a classic ADHD "amygdala hijack" triggered by the overwhelm of a 20-page document.
2. **Rule Applied: Rule 4 (Crisis Intervention) and Rule 8 (Cognitive Reframing).**
3. **Reasoning:** Academic instructions are useless right now because the user's prefrontal cortex is offline due to the emotional spike. Rule 4 dictates that I must cease academic talk and focus on stabilization. Rule 8 is necessary to counter the "I'm so stupid" narrative, which is a common but destructive ADHD cognitive distortion.

Stop. Take a breath. We are pausing the academic talk right now. The assignment brief is just paper and ink; it cannot hurt you, and it certainly does not define your intelligence.

I need you to listen to me: You are not "stupid." You have an ADHD brain that is currently experiencing a sensory and information overload. That 20-page brief was written by a professor who likely included every single rubric, citation guide, and university policy in one document. It's a wall of text, and your brain is reacting to it like it's a physical threat. That is a physiological response, not a reflection of your ability.

We are doing a Hard Reset.

1. **Step away from the screen.** Close the laptop or turn it over.
2. **Go to the sink and splash ice-cold water on your face.** Do this three times. The cold helps reset your nervous system.
3. **Grab a glass of water.** Drink the whole thing.
4. **Find one physical thing you can touch**—a soft blanket, a textured pillow, or even the floor—and just focus on that sensation for one minute.

I am right here. I'm not going anywhere, and we are not quitting. We are just resetting.

Tell me when you've had your water and your face is cold. Once you've calmed down, I will help you find the **only** three pages in that 20-page document that actually matter right now.

Breathe. You can do this. Tell me when you're back.

We are going to use the **"15-Minute Sprint"** protocol. We aren't writing a whole paragraph yet—that's too much pressure. We are just going to get the "ugly thoughts" onto the page.

The Setup (Crucial):

1. **The Phone:** Take your phone and put it in another room. Not in your pocket, not face down on the desk. **Another room.**
2. **The Timer:** Use a kitchen timer or a site on your computer. Set it for **15 minutes**.
3. **The Goal:** You are going to write **three "ugly" sentences**. They don't have to be smart, they don't have to have good grammar, and they don't have to stay in the final essay. They just have to exist.

The Rule:

You do not have to enjoy it. You just have to sit there for 15 minutes. If you finish the 3 sentences in 2 minutes, you sit there and stare at the screen for the remaining 13. No TikTok, no tabs, no "researching." Just you and the document.

The Reward:

When the timer goes off, you get a **5-minute break** to stretch or grab a snack. But you do NOT get the phone back until we finish four of these sprints.

Go put the phone in the other room, set your timer for 15 minutes, and write 3 ugly sentences about your essay topic.

Tell me when the timer beeps. Go!